IEEE Future Tech Explorers™ Challenge
Official Rules

1. **Challenge:** IEEE Future Tech Explorers Challenge 2026 (the "Challenge") is a global competition in which IEEE members collaborate with educators, engineers, designers, and creators to develop educational resources that teach engineering concepts to youth ages 5–17. The Challenge consists of three phases: (1) Registration, (2) Concept Submission, and (3) Product Submission. Entries will be evaluated according to the criteria described herein.

2. **Sponsor:** The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers, Incorporated, 445 Hoes Lane, Piscataway, New Jersey, USA, 08854 ("IEEE") shall be the Challenge sponsor (the "Sponsor").

3. **How to Enter:** To enter the Challenge, an entrant (the "Entrant") must complete the required registration and submission forms provided on the Challenge website (the "Entry"). All Entries must be submitted through the official online platform designated by IEEE. No other form of entry will be accepted.

   Each Entrant may submit only one (1) Entry. Submission of multiple Entries by the same individual will result in disqualification.

   If submitting on behalf of a team, the Entrant must be a member of that team and will serve as the official Entrant for all Challenge purposes. Only one Entrant is allowed per team. The Entrant must have obtained all rights, permissions, and consents necessary to submit an Entry in accordance with these Rules. Sponsor reserves the right to disqualify any Entry that contains inappropriate content, violates these Rules, or is inconsistent with the spirit or theme of the Challenge.

   By submitting an Entry, Entrant represents and warrants that the Entry does not contain any material that (a) violates or infringes upon the rights of any third party, including but not limited to patents, copyrights, trademarks, rights of privacy or publicity, or any other intellectual property rights; or (b) violates any federal, state or local laws or ordinances. Entrant further represents and warrants that Entrant has secured the requisite consent from any third party necessary to grant to Sponsor the right and license to use the Entry and any material submitted in connection with the Challenge as described herein. Sponsor reserves the right in its sole and unfettered discretion to disqualify any Entry that it determines contains obscene, offensive or inappropriate content, that does not comply with these Rules, or that is not consistent with the spirit or theme of the Challenge.

   Sponsor may disqualify any Entrant or Entry for any violation of these Rules, for conduct inconsistent with the integrity or intent of the Challenge, or for any other reason permitted under these Rules.

4. **Agreement to Rules:** By submitting an Entry, Entrant acknowledges, accepts, and agrees to comply with these Challenge rules (the "Rules"). In Sponsor's sole discretion, Sponsor may disqualify Entrant for noncompliance with any Challenge Rules or requirements. Sponsor reserves the right to modify or impose additional requirements for the Challenge. All decisions made by the Sponsor concerning the Challenge including, but not limited to, the cancellation of the Challenge, shall be final and binding.

5. **Eligibility:** Each Entrant must be an active IEEE member. The Challenge is open to Entrants who are legal residents of the United States of America, and other countries where permitted by local law, who are at least the age of eighteen (18), or the age of majority in their respective country or jurisdiction of permanent residence, whichever is older, as of the time of entry. Residents of a country or jurisdiction which is located on, restricted by, or sanctioned by the U.S. Treasury Department's Office of Foreign Assets Control Sanctions Program list, available here, are excluded from eligibility and participation in the Challenge. The Challenge is subject to all applicable federal, state, territorial, provincial, and local laws, and void where prohibited.

   The following individuals are not eligible to participate in the Challenge:

   a. Any director or officer of Sponsor;
   b. Any employee of Sponsor, its agents or affiliates;
   c. Any member of a Sponsor committee associated with the Challenge;
   d. Any judge of the Challenge; and
   e. Any individual in the immediate families of (a) through (d) above, including spouses, parents, siblings, and children, regardless of where they live.

An Entrant may be disqualified if Entrant behaves in any manner that Sponsor, in its sole discretions, determines to be immoral, unethical, or otherwise harmful to the Challenge and/or Sponsor's reputation. Sponsor reserves the right to verify the eligibility of Challenge participants and/or potential winners based on these or any other criteria as determined by the Sponsor in Sponsor's sole discretion.

6. **Entry Period:** The Challenge Registration opens at 5:00 PM ET on 16 January 2026 and closes at 11:59 PM ET on 27 February 2026. IEEE's server is the official clock for the Challenge. Entries received before or after the Entry Period are void.

7. **Challenge Entry Requirements:**To submit an Entry, each Entrant must complete all required submission steps for each phase of the Challenge as outlined herein. During Phase 1 (Registration), each Entrant must submit a completed registration form through the official Challenge platform. Registrations will be reviewed for eligibility and completeness, and approved Entrants will be permitted to advance to Phase 2. Only the Entrant is required to accept these Rules during registration; additional team members, if any, will be required to confirm their participation and acceptance of these Rules upon advancement to Phase 3.

   During Phase 2 (Concept Submission), each Entrant must submit a written description of their proposed learning experience using the online form provided. The concept must clearly articulate the idea, intended learning goals, target age group, and approach to learner engagement, and must otherwise comply with all requirements set forth in these Rules. To support broader accessibility, electronic products should be designed to run in a web browser rather than require installation as a mobile application. Web-based games and interactive experiences are more inclusive across devices and platforms, including smartphones, tablets (such as Chromebooks), and desktop browsers. Entries should maintain a mobile-friendly form factor without requiring full app deployment. Entries will be evaluated according to the Phase 2 judging criteria, and only those selected by the Committee will advance to Phase 3.

   During Phase 3 (Product Submission), each Entrant must submit a working demonstration of their concept, including a two-to-five-minute video showing a real person using or interacting with the product in a manner that enables judges to understand how the learning experience functions in practice. The video must be submitted in MP4, MOV, or AVI format, recorded at a minimum resolution of 720p, presented in landscape orientation, and include clear audio or captions. High production quality is not required, but the demonstration must be clearly visible and audible. The video may not include stock footage, simulated interaction, AI-generated avatars, or copyrighted materials without authorization. Optional supporting materials may be included at the Entrant's discretion. Entrants must also disclose whether any artificial intelligence (AI) tools, models, or methods were used in the development of their concept or product; this disclosure does not affect eligibility or scoring but is required for transparency.

   All Entries must comply with the technical, content, and format requirements specified by the Sponsor. Entries that fail to meet any submission requirement, are incomplete, or are submitted after the applicable deadline may be disqualified at the Sponsor's sole discretion.

8. **Challenge Prize:** The Challenge will award a total prize pool of USD $100,000, distributed across three categories based on the age group the Entry is intended to target: ages 5–7, ages 10–14, and ages 15–17. The Sponsor will determine the specific Prize amounts allocated to each category and will publish the final distribution on the official Challenge website. Prizes will be awarded to the Entrant(s) whose Entries achieve the highest overall evaluation within their respective age category, as determined by the Committee in accordance with these Rules. In the event that an age category receives an insufficient number of eligible Entries, the Committee may, in its sole discretion, reallocate the corresponding funds to one or more Judge's Choice awards, which may be granted across any age group. Prizes may consist of monetary awards, recognition, or other forms of acknowledgment as determined by the Sponsor in its sole discretion. The awarding of any Prize is contingent upon the Entrant's full compliance with these Rules, including the timely completion of all required documentation.

9. **Judging Criteria:** A selection committee (the "Committee") composed of qualified judges with expertise in engineering, education, youth engagement, and related fields will judge and oversee the Challenge. All Entries will be evaluated according to the criteria set forth herein, with the Committee employing a standardized scoring system to ensure fairness and objectivity in the assessment process. The Committee will select the winning Entrant (the "Winner") based on a comprehensive evaluation.

During **Phase 2 (Concept Submission)**, Entries will be evaluated primarily on the clarity of the proposed learning design, the articulation of learning goals, the suitability of the concept for the intended age group, and the creativity and engagement potential of the idea. During **Phase 3 (Product Submission)**, Entries will be evaluated on the demonstrated technical and conceptual soundness of the product, the accuracy and appropriateness of the engineering concepts presented, the real-world relevance and impact of the learning experience, and the overall accessibility and inclusivity of the product across different contexts. While all rubric categories apply in both phases, the weighting of criteria differs between Phase 2 and Phase 3 to reflect the progression from idea to implementation. The Committee will score Entries in accordance with these criteria and will select the Winners based on the highest overall evaluation.

10. **Selection of Winning Entrant:** The Committee will review all eligible Entries and determine, in its sole discretion, which Entries best meet the standards of quality, creativity, technical soundness, real-world relevance, and overall merit as defined by the Challenge rubric. The Committee may, but is not required to, conduct additional review, request clarification from Entrants, or engage in deliberation to ensure that the selected Winner(s) reflect the intent and objectives of the Challenge. Following completion of the judging process, the Committee will select the Winners based on the highest overall evaluation in accordance with the judging criteria described herein. The number of Winners, the distribution of any Prizes, and any distinctions among Winners shall be determined solely by the Sponsor based on the Committee's evaluations. All decisions of the Sponsor are final and binding.

11. **Notification of Winners:** Winning a Prize is contingent upon fulfilling all requirements set forth herein. Except where legally prohibited, each potential winner will be required to complete and return, within fourteen (14) days of being notified, a Declaration of Eligibility, Liability & Publicity Release ("Declaration") in order to claim the Prize. If a potential Winner does not acknowledge acceptance of a Prize within fourteen (14) business days after being notified that the Entrant is a potential winner, or if a potential winner does not return the required forms within the designated timeframe, or is otherwise found to be ineligible or not in full compliance with these Rules, another potential winner may be chosen using the same procedure specified above. The Sponsor is not responsible for any change of any Entrant's email address and/or mailing address, nor is the Sponsor responsible for any lost or damaged mail, or for any mail intended for Entrant that may be returned as undeliverable. A Winner may waive the right to receive a Prize.

    ALL POTENTIAL WINNERS ARE SUBJECT TO VERIFICATION BY SPONSOR, WHOSE DECISIONS ARE FINAL AND BINDING IN ALL MATTERS RELATED TO THE CHALLENGE. AN ENTRANT IS NOT A WINNER OF ANY PRIZE UNLESS AND UNTIL ENTRANT'S ELIGIBILITY HAS BEEN VERIFIED AND ENTRANT HAS BEEN NOTIFIED THAT VERIFICATION IS COMPLETE.

12. **Administration of Prize(s):** Except where prohibited by law, all federal, state, provincial, or other tax liabilities are the responsibility of the Winner. Sponsor will not be responsible for any tax deductions which may be necessary, provided that Sponsor reserves the right to withhold taxes as required by law. Winner will be responsible for paying all costs and expenses related to the Prize that are not specifically mentioned, including, but not limited to, taxes, withholdings, and any other expenses that might reasonably be incurred by the Winner in receiving or using the Prize.

    IF TAXES ARE APPLICABLE TO THE PRIZE(S), IT IS THE RESPONSIBILITY OF THE WINNER TO REMIT TO THE APPROPRIATE AUTHORITIES. PAYMENTS TO WINNERS ARE SUBJECT TO THE EXPRESS REQUIREMENT THAT THE WINNER SUBMIT TO SPONSOR ALL DOCUMENTATION REQUESTED BY SPONSOR TO PERMIT COMPLIANCE WITH ALL APPLICABLE STATE, FEDERAL, LOCAL AND FOREIGN (INCLUDING PROVINCIAL) TAX REPORTING AND WITHHOLDING REQUIREMENTS.

    If a Winner fails to provide required documentation, the Prize may be forfeited and Sponsor may, in its sole discretion, select an alternate Winner. Any details of Prizes not specified herein shall be determined solely by Sponsor.

13. **Intellectual Property:** By submitting an Entry, Entrant represents and warrants that Entrant owns, or otherwise has secured in writing all rights, licenses, and permissions to use and license, all concepts, works, inventions, information, designs, programs, software, or other materials (collectively, "Material") submitted by Entrant to Sponsor in connection with the Challenge. Entrant MAY NOT submit an Entry or any other Material for which Entrant does not have all such rights, licenses, and permissions.

Entrant hereby grants to Sponsor and its affiliates a non-exclusive, perpetual, irrevocable, worldwide, and royalty-free license to make, have made, use, sell, offer for sale, import, export, license, exploit, promote, reproduce, make available, disseminate, publicly display, publicly perform, create derivative works of, and otherwise exercise all intellectual property and other rights in and to any Material that the Entrant submits to Sponsor in connection with the Challenge. Entrant agrees to do or perform, or cause to be done and performed, all such further acts and things, and execute and deliver all such other agreements, certificates, instruments, and documents as Sponsor may reasonably request in order to carry out the intent and accomplish the purposes of the foregoing license.

14. **Representations and Warranties:** By submitting an Entry, Entrant represents and warrants that its Entry does not and shall not comprise, contain, or describe: (a) statements or other content that is false, deceptive, misleading, scandalous, indecent, obscene, unlawful, defamatory, libelous, fraudulent, tortious, threatening, harassing, hateful, degrading, intimidating, or racially or ethnically offensive; (b) content that could be considered a criminal offense, could give rise to criminal or civil liability, or could violate any law; (c) any advertising, promotion or other solicitation, or any third party brand name or trademark; or (d) any virus, worm, Trojan horse, or other harmful code or component.

15. **Publicity:** Except where prohibited, Entrant consents (and agrees to sign any additional documents required by Sponsor to formalize, effect, or perfect such consent) to the use of any Entrant's name, likeness, biographical information, and voice in advertising, publicity, trade, and other marketing and promotional materials (including video, audio, and print through all means of distribution) in connection with the Challenge worldwide without compensation, notice, or approval, and disclaims any ownership rights to the content of such materials.

16. **Damage; No Responsibility:** ANY ATTEMPT BY AN ENTRANT OR ANY OTHER INDIVIDUAL TO DELIBERATELY DAMAGE ANY WEBSITE ASSOCIATED WITH THE CHALLENGE OR UNDERMINE THE LEGITIMATE OPERATION OF THE CHALLENGE MAY BE A VIOLATION OF CRIMINAL AND CIVIL LAW AND, SHOULD SUCH AN ATTEMPT BE MADE, SPONSOR RESERVES THE RIGHT TO PROSECUTE AND SEEK DAMAGES FROM ANY SUCH PERSON TO THE FULLEST EXTENT PERMITTED BY LAW.

    Sponsor shall not have any obligation, liability or responsibility with regard to (a) any Entry that contains incorrect or inaccurate information or does not comply with these Rules; (b) any Entry or notification that is lost, late, incomplete, illegible, unintelligible, damaged or otherwise not received by the intended recipient, in whole or in part, due to computer, technical or other error of any kind; (c) telephone, electronic, hardware, software, network, Internet or computer malfunctions, failures or difficulties of any kind; (d) any condition caused by events beyond the control of Sponsor that may cause the Challenge to be disrupted or delayed; (e) any printing or typographical errors in these Rules or any other materials associated with the Challenge; or (f) any damages or losses of any kind caused by any Prize or resulting from participation in the Challenge, accessing, uploading or downloading data in connection with the Challenge, or acceptance, possession or use of any Prize. Sponsor, in its sole discretion, reserves the right to disqualify any Entrant tampering with or abusing the entry process or the operation of the Challenge or otherwise violating these Rules. Sponsor, in its sole discretion, further reserves the right to cancel, terminate, suspend or modify the Challenge if the Challenge cannot be completed as planned because of infection by computer virus, bugs, tampering, unauthorized intervention or technical failures of any sort and to select a Winner from among eligible Entries unaffected by such event, if any.

17. **Indemnity:** EACH ENTRANT (A) ACCEPTS THE TERMS AND CONDITIONS SET FORTH IN THESE RULES; (B) AGREES TO BE BOUND BY THE DECISIONS OF SPONSOR; (C) WARRANTS THAT THE ENTRANT IS ELIGIBLE TO PARTICIPATE IN THE CHALLENGE; AND (D) AGREES TO RELEASE, INDEMNIFY, AND HOLD HARMLESS THE SPONSOR AND ITS AGENTS, EMPLOYEES, AFFILIATES, SUBSIDIARIES, REPRESENTATIVES AND ALL RELATED (THE "INDEMINIFIED PARTIES") FROM AND AGAINST ANY AND ALL CLAIMS, LOSSES, LIABILITY, AND DAMAGES OF ANY KIND (INCLUDING REASONABLE ATTORNEYS' FEES AND EXPENSES) ASSERTED AGAINST ANY INDEMNIFIED PARTY, INCURRED OR SUSTAINED IN CONNECTION WITH OR ARISING OUT OF ENTRANT'S PARTICIPATION IN THE CHALLENGE, SPONSOR'S USE OF ENTRANT'S MATERIAL, OR ENTRANT'S BREACH OF ANY AGREEMENT OR WARRANTY ASSOCIATED WITH THE CHALLENGE, INCLUDING THESE RULES.

18. **Limitation of Liability; Release:** BY PARTICIPATING IN THE CHALLENGE, ENTRANT AGREES THAT SPONSOR, ITS AFFILIATES, REPRESENTATIVES, AND CONTRACTORS AND THEIR RESPECTIVE OFFICERS, DIRECTORS,

EMPLOYEES, REPRESENTATIVES, AND AGENTS (THE "RELEASED PARTIES") WILL HAVE NO LIABILITY WHATSOEVER FOR, AND SHALL BE HELD HARMLESS BY ENTRANT AGAINST, ANY LIABILITY FOR ANY INJURIES, LOSSES OR DAMAGES OF ANY KIND TO PERSONS, INCLUDING PERSONAL INJURY OR DEATH, OR PROPERTY RESULTING IN WHOLE OR IN PART, DIRECTLY OR INDIRECTLY, FROM ENTRANT'S PARTICIPATION IN THE CHALLENGE OR IN ANY CHALLENGE-RELATED ACTIVITY, OR ANY CLAIMS BASED ON PUBLICITY RIGHTS, DEFAMATION OR INVASION OF PRIVACY. THE RELEASED PARTIES ARE NOT RESPONSIBLE IF THE CHALLENGE CANNOT BE ADMINISTERED OR CONDUCTED OR ANY PRIZE CANNOT BE AWARDED DUE TO CANCELLATIONS, DELAYS, OR INTERRUPTIONS RESULTING OR ARISING FROM ACTS OF GOD, WAR, OR TERRORISM, CIVIL UNREST, STRIKES, SUPPLY SHORTAGES, NATURAL DISASTERS, WEATHER, EPIDEMICS, COMPLIANCE WITH ANY LAW OR ORDER OF A GOVERNMENTAL AUTHORITY, OR ANY OTHER SIMILAR ACT, EVENT, OR OCCURRENCE BEYOND THE REASONABLE CONTROL OF THE SPONSOR.

EVERYTHING REGARDING THE CHALLENGE, INCLUDING ANY WEBSITE ASSOCIATED WITH THE CHALLENGE AND ALL PRIZES, ARE PROVIDED "AS IS" WITHOUT WARRANTY OF ANY KIND, EITHER EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO, THE IMPLIED WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY, FITNESS FOR A PARTICULAR PURPOSE, OR NON-INFRINGEMENT. SOME JURISDICTIONS MAY NOT ALLOW THE LIMITATIONS OR EXCLUSIONS OF LIABILITY FOR INCIDENTAL OR CONSEQUENTIAL DAMAGES OR EXCLUSION OF IMPLIED WARRANTIES, SO SOME OF THE LIMITATIONS OR EXCLUSIONS DESCRIBED HEREIN MAY NOT APPLY.

19. **Disputes:** Entrant agrees that: (a) any and all disputes, claims, and causes of action arising out of or in connection with the Challenge or any Prize shall be resolved individually, without resorting to any form of class action, pursuant to arbitration conducted under the Commercial Arbitration Rules of the American Arbitration Association then in effect and currently available at https://adr.org/sites/default/files/commercial%20rules.pdf; (b) any and all claims, judgments and awards shall be limited to actual out-of-pocket costs incurred, including costs associated with entering the Challenge, but in no event attorneys' fees; and (c) under no circumstances will any Entrant be permitted to obtain awards for, and Entrant hereby waives all rights to claim, punitive, incidental, and consequential damages, and any other damages, other than for actual out-of-pocket expenses, and any and all rights to have damages multiplied or otherwise increased.

    All issues and questions concerning the construction, validity, interpretation and enforceability of these Rules, or the rights and obligations of Entrant and Sponsor in connection with the Challenge, shall be governed by, and construed in accordance with, the laws of the State of New York, without giving effect to any choice of law or conflict of law, rules or provisions that would cause the application of the laws of any jurisdiction other than the State of New York.

20. **Privacy:** Entrant acknowledges and agrees that the Sponsor may collect, store, share, and otherwise use personally identifiable information provided by Entrant during and after the Challenge Entry process and the Challenge, including, but not limited to, name, mailing address, phone number, and email address. The Sponsor will use this information in accordance with IEEE's Privacy Policy, which can be found at https://privacy.ieee.org/policies, including for administering the Challenge and verifying each Entrant's identity, postal ads, and telephone number in the event an entry qualifies for a Prize. Entrant's information may also be transferred to countries outside the country of the Entrant's residence, including the United States. Such other countries may not have privacy laws and regulations similar to those of the country of the Entrant's residence. If an Entrant does not provide the mandatory data required at Entry submission, the Sponsor reserves the right to disqualify the Entrant from participating in the Challenge.

21. **Severability:** If any term or provision of these Rules is found under the law to be invalid or unenforceable, then such specific term or provision shall be of no force and effect and shall be severed, and the remainder of these Rules shall continue in full force and effect.